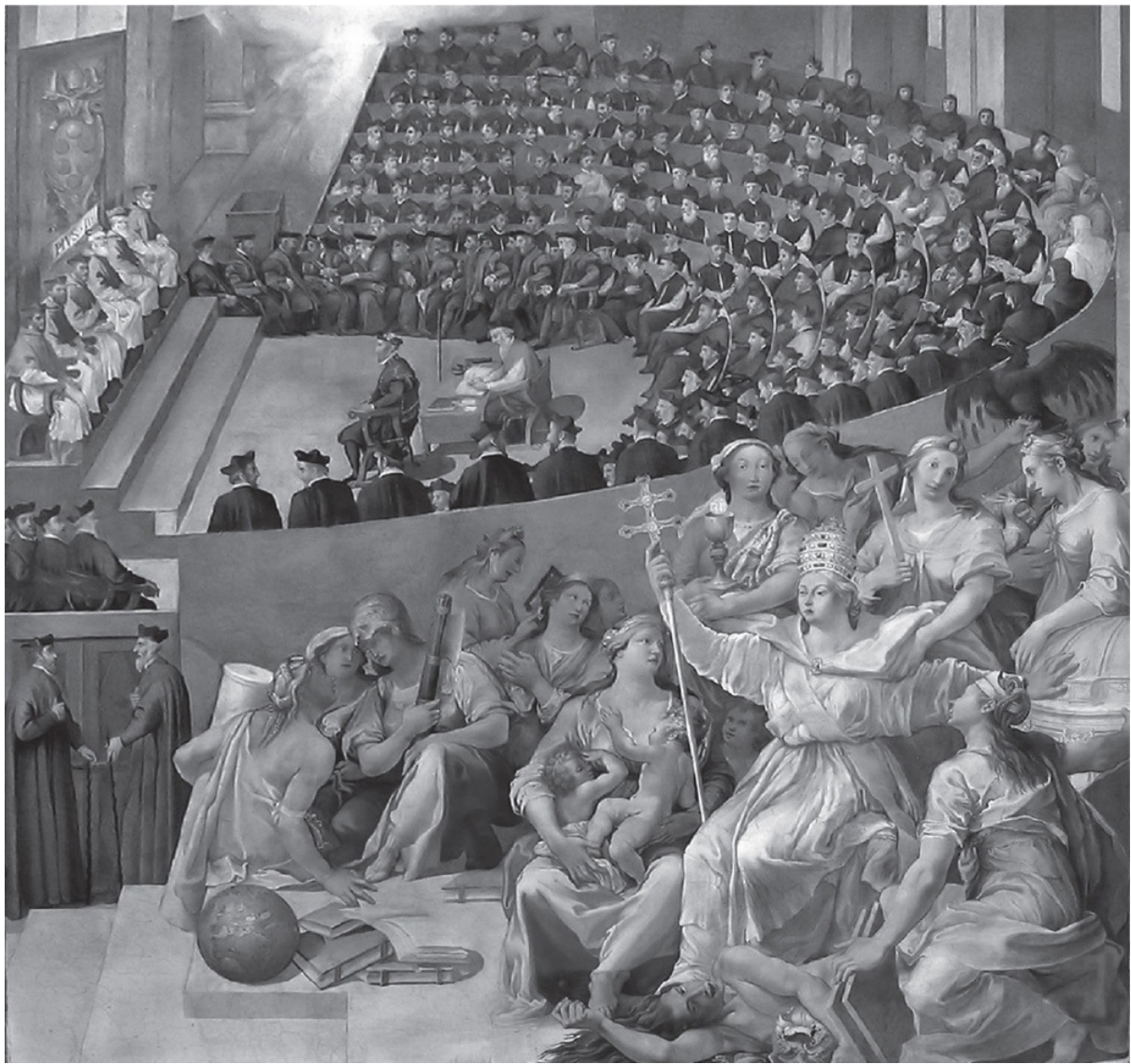


The Counter-Reformation

Until the Reformation, the Roman Catholic Church had dominated western Europe for a thousand years. Starting in Germany, the ideas of Protestantism spread quickly throughout Europe, and traditions of Catholic art were rejected. In place of art that venerated Jesus, Mary and the saints, Protestants encouraged moralistic depictions of secular life that could not be mistaken for idolatry. Printmaking, which allowed images to be mass-produced at low cost, was also encouraged.

In response, between 1545 and 1563, the Catholic Church held the Council of Trent, resulting in a Counter-Reformation that aimed to revive Catholicism. One area of discussion considered how art in Catholic countries, especially Italy, currently emphasized ornament over religious subjects, and an edict was duly passed that art must be strictly religious. Certain subjects were given increased precedence, and as the Counter-Reformation gained strength and the Church felt less threatened, it used the arts as a way of articulating a message of Catholic dominance.



Pasquale Cati, *The Council of Trent*, 1588